



THE GREAT WALL

During the Ming era, the Great Wall of China was expanded and strengthened against invasions from the north. Ming emperors rebuilt more than 3,890 miles (6,260 km) of the wall. New techniques allowed the wall to be reinforced with battlements, watchtowers, and fortresses. It is these Ming defenses that are still visible today.

ZHENG HE

Zheng He (1371–c. 1433) was an explorer who led seven expeditions to Southeast Asia, India, and along the East African coast. He commanded up to 30,000 soldiers and his vast wooden ships were among the largest ever built at the time.



Blue dragon design on a Ming era porcelain jar

◀ PORCELAIN

In an effort to bring back old traditions, the first Ming emperor reestablished the imperial porcelain factory in 1369, which had been founded by the Song Dynasty. The factory refined old techniques and styles, especially the blue-and-white porcelain. This distinctive pottery became famous across the world and was often given away by the imperial family as gifts.

THE FORBIDDEN CITY ▶

In 1406, Emperor Yongle ordered the construction of a new palace complex in Beijing, which was to become his new capital. The complex was divided into two parts: the inner court was used by the imperial family, and the outer court was used by the emperor and his officials. As access to the complex was restricted, it became known as the Forbidden City.



The northern gate, or "Gate of Divine Might"

MAJOR EVENTS

1368

Zhu Yuanzhang seizes power from the Mongols and establishes the new Ming Dynasty, reigning as Emperor Hongwu.

1402–1424

Emperor Yongle orders the reconstruction of China's Grand Canal. Once the Forbidden City is complete, he moves the capital to Beijing.

1425–1435

Emperor Xuande puts down rebellions in the empire and tries to stop corruption among officials. His reign sees a high point in making blue-and-white porcelain.

1449

Emperor Zhengtong is captured by the Mongols after defeat in battle. The event leads to the rebuilding of the Great Wall.

1644

Emperor Chongzhen, the last Ming ruler, dies in 1644. The Ming Dynasty is overthrown by the Manchus.